turmeric. Erode in Tamil Nadu is the World's largest wholesale turmeric market.

Uses

Turmeric is one of the most important and ancient Indian spices and used traditionally over thousands of years for culinary, cosmetic, dyeing and for medicinal purposes. It is an important constituent of curry powders. Turmeric is used as a colouring agent in pharmacy, confectionery and food industry. Rice coloured with turmeric (yellow) is considered sacred and auspicious which is used in ceremonies. It is also used for dyeing leather, fibre, paper and toys.

Curcumin extracted from turmeric is responsible for the yellow colour. Curcumin is a very good anti-oxidant which may help fight various kinds of cancer. It has anti-inflammatory, anti-diabetic, anti-bacterial, anti-fungal and anti-viral activities. It stops platelets from clotting in arteries, which leads to heart attack.

Chillies / Red Pepper

Botanical name : *Capsicum annuum, C. frutescens.*

Family : Solanaceae

Origin and Area of cultivation: Capsicum is native to South America and is popularly known as chillies or red pepper in English. India is leading producer and exporter. *C. annuum* and *C. frutescens* are important cultivated species of chillies.

Uses

The fruits of *C.annuum* are less pungent than the fruits of *C.frutescens*. *C.annum* includes large, sweet bell peppers. Long fruit cultivars of this species are commercially known as 'Cayenne pepper' which are crushed, powdered and used as condiment. Chillies are used in manufacture of sauces, curry powders and preparation of pickles. Capsaicin is an active component of chillies. It has pain relieving properties and used in pain relieving balms. Chillies are a good source of Vitamin C, A and E.



Capsaicin is responsible for the pungency or spicy taste of chillies. Pungency of Chillies is measured in Scoville Heat Units (SHU). World's hottest chilli, Carolina reaper pepper measures 2,200,000 SHU. Naga viper chilli is the hottest in India that measures 1,349,000 SHU. Commonly used cayenne pepper measures 30,000 to 50,000 SHU.

Condiment

Tamarind

Botanical name :*Tamarindus indica*

Family : Fabaceae-Caesalpinioideae

Origin and Area of cultivation: Tamarind is native of tropical African region and was introduced into India several thousand years before. It is cultivated in India, Myanmar, south asian countries and several African and Central American countries.



Figure 10.13 : Tamarind

Table 10.2 : Other common spices and condiments

S. No	Common Name	Tamil Name	Botanical Name	Family
1	Coriander	கொத்துமல்லி	*Coriandrum sativum.* L	Apiaceae
2	Cumin	சீரகம்	*Cuminum cyminum.* L	Apiaceae
3	Fenugreek	வெந்தயம்	*Trigonella foenum graecum.* L	Fabaceae
4	Cloves	இலவங்கம்	*Eugenia aromaticum*	Myrtaceae
5	Asafoetidia	பெருங்காயம்	*Ferula asafoetida.*L	Umbelliferae (Apiaceae)
6	Onion	வெங்காயம்	*Allium cepa*	Amarillidaceae

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